

Reading for Meaning

1. Why was cooking so important to the people during the Cultural Revolution?

(Paragraph 1) During this time, people were not free to express their thoughts on many topics. Cooking was important because it was one of the few things people were still allowed to discuss, share ideas about, and argue over freely.

2. Why are music and cooking linked together in the writer's memory? Give two reasons.

(Paragraph 2) * Reason 1: They were the only two constant forms of education he received as a child.

- **Reason 2:** In his courtyard, the sounds of music (practising and singing) always happened at the same time as the sounds and smells of cooking.

3. How did the Chinese peasants in the countryside take advantage of the freezing cold temperatures? (Paragraph 3) They used the freezing weather as a natural refrigerator. They would pack thousands of dumplings into clay pots and leave them outside. The cold kept the dumplings frozen and fresh for many months.

4. Why was the writer's mother feeling sad as she walked with her son through the alleys?

(Paragraph 4) She was sad because they were so poor that she had to sell her late husband's special performance clothes (his blue music jacket and gown) just to buy basic food like grain and vegetables.

5. Why do you think the writer's mother said 'yes' in answer to her son's question? Give two reasons. (Paragraph 4) * Reason 1:

She wanted to comfort her son and give him hope, even though she knew they likely wouldn't be able to buy the clothes back.

- **Reason 2:** She wanted to protect him from the painful reality of how desperate their financial situation really was.

6. Explain why the writer walked home 'feeling happy' in the final paragraph. Give at least three reasons. (Paragraph 5) * Reason 1:

He had just eaten a delicious and nutritious meal of dumpling soup and rice.

- **Reason 2:** He felt treated and special because he had never been to a restaurant before.
- **Reason 3:** He felt deep love and appreciation for his mother, believing she was "the best mother" for giving him such a treat despite their poverty.

7. What is the word in the writer's mother tongue for the traditional gown worn by a musical performer? The word is chang-shan.

Vocabulary

1. Write sentences of your own to illustrate the meanings of the following words:

- **a) Maze:** The old part of the city was a **maze** of narrow streets where it was easy to get lost.
- **b) Amaze:** The magician's clever card tricks never fail to **amaze** the audience.
- **c) Maize:** In many parts of the world, **maize** is a very important crop used to make flour and oil.